

Florida Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Intelligence

Situational Awareness Bulletin #01-2026

Cyber Threat Outlook and Executive Summary

The current cyber threat landscape for critical infrastructure (CI) is defined by a convergence of state-sponsored espionage, disruptive hacktivism, and sophisticated ransomware campaigns that are increasingly blurring the boundaries between digital and physical CI hazards. Over the next 6–9 months, CI owners and operators should anticipate a continued evolution of "living off the land" tactics, where attackers like those targeting the Romanian water sector use legitimate administrative tools to evade detection. Tactically, the most pressing priority is the immediate remediation of misconfigured edge devices and the rapid patching of essential collaboration software, as evidenced by the coordinated Chinese exploitation of Microsoft SharePoint. Systemic risks are also rising due to the emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) driven penetration agents like ARTEMIS, which can outperform human experts in identifying network vulnerabilities at scale. Strategic resource decisions should prioritize aggressive network segmentation and formalization of manual fallback procedures to ensure operational continuity during prolonged digital outages. Florida's unique position as a maritime and technological hub necessitates a transition from reactive hardening to proactive, automated defense and rigorous third-party risk management.

- **All Sectors:** Emerging AI penetration tools like ARTEMIS have demonstrated the ability to outperform 90% of human cybersecurity professionals, identifying network vulnerabilities at a fraction of traditional costs. Concurrently, pro-Russian hacktivists have escalated their operations from simple service disruptions to probing the operational technology (OT) interfaces of critical utilities.
- **Communications:** Finnish authorities seized a vessel suspected of physical sabotage against subsea telecommunications cables in the Baltic Sea, highlighting the vulnerability of critical maritime data links.
- **Emergency Services:** An unauthorized hijack of public tornado sirens in Dallas used to play a cartoon theme song demonstrated the susceptibility of public warning systems to outside interference.
- **Energy:** Russia's Main Intelligence Directorate (GRU) is conducting a multi-year campaign targeting Western energy providers, increasingly exploiting device misconfigurations for stealthy persistence. Concurrently, the APT28 group has initiated credential-harvesting attacks using localized lures to target energy research and nuclear agencies.

- **Financial Services:** State-sponsored North Korean threat groups have achieved record success, stealing over \$2 billion in cryptocurrency this year to fund national programs.
- **Healthcare and Public Health:** Major healthcare breaches, such as the Covenant Health incident, have required massive scope revisions, ultimately impacting hundreds of thousands more individuals than initially reported.
- **Information Technology:** Three coordinated Chinese hacking groups contemporaneously exploited zero-day vulnerabilities in Microsoft SharePoint to target hundreds of government and enterprise networks globally.
- **Water and Wastewater Systems:** A ransomware attack against Romania's national water agency leveraged the legitimate Windows tool BitLocker to lock 1,000 systems, demonstrating a potent "living off the land" threat to utility information technology (IT) infrastructure.

All Sectors

Artificial Intelligence Agent Outperforms Human Cybersecurity Professionals in Network Penetration

Stanford researchers recently deployed an AI agent named ARTEMIS, which successfully identified nine valid vulnerabilities across 8,000 devices in a sixteen-hour test, outperforming 90% of professional human penetration testers. ARTEMIS used a unique technique of spinning up "sub-agents" to investigate multiple targets simultaneously and bypassed common human-centric obstacles, such as browser loading refusals, by using command-line requests. This development highlights how AI significantly lowers the barrier to sophisticated hacking, allowing malicious actors to scale effective attacks at a fraction of the cost of human experts.

Pro-Russian Hacktivist Campaign Targets French Postal, Financial, and Operational Technology Systems

In late December 2025, the pro-Russian group NoName057(16) launched a massive DDoS campaign against the French national postal service (La Poste) and its banking arm, disrupting digital identity and mobile services during the holiday peak. Simultaneously, related groups like the Z-Pentest Alliance claimed unauthorized access to the SCADA interfaces of two French water treatment plants. This represents a growing trend of hacktivist groups moving beyond service disruption toward the potential sabotage of operational technology in the finance, transportation, and water sectors.

All Sectors - Recommendations

- Implement DDoS mitigation services utilizing cloud-based scrubbing centers, Anycast architectures, and intelligent rate limiting.

- Ensure strict network segmentation between external web interfaces and core industrial control systems.
- Prioritize the continuous patching of older servers, as AI agents effectively bypass human-centric interface limitations via command-line requests.
- Deploy next-generation security tools capable of detecting the multi-threaded scanning and exploitation characteristic of AI agents.

Chemical Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Commercial Facilities Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Communications Sector

Physical Threat to Undersea Telecommunications Cables Investigated in the Baltic Sea

Finnish authorities seized a suspect ship on December 31, 2025, following reports of physical damage to subsea telecommunications cables owned by Elisa and Arelion. The vessel was found with its anchor chain lowered, suggesting damage caused by anchor dragging near Estonia. These incidents highlight the vulnerability of essential global data links to physical interference, a high-value risk for Florida given its status as a major nexus for sensitive subsea telecommunications cables.

Communications Sector - Recommendations

- Increase physical monitoring of sensitive subsea cable landing sites and related terrestrial infrastructure.
- Review organizational redundancy protocols to ensure service continuity even if major transmission routes are severed.
- Consult maritime partners regarding suspicious vessel activity near vital cable routes, specifically assessing the risk of anchor dragging.

Critical Manufacturing Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Dams Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Defense Industrial Base Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Emergency Services Sector

Unauthorized Broadcast Disrupts Dallas Emergency Warning System

On December 9, 2025, an unknown hacker gained unauthorized access to the Dallas emergency alert system, hijacking tornado sirens to play the "SpongeBob SquarePants" theme song for approximately one hour. While city officials confirmed the event was a non-destructive prank, it demonstrates the susceptibility of public warning systems (a form of OT) to unauthorized access and interference. For Florida, weather-related emergency system integrity is paramount, making this a critical area for audit and hardening.

Emergency Services Sector - Recommendations

- Audit all public-facing emergency alert system infrastructure for exposed or default administrator interfaces and enforce strong authentication.
- Segment the network carrying alert system commands from the public internet.
- Develop and test contingency procedures to rapidly override unauthorized broadcasts and confirm system status to the public.

Energy Sector

Amazon Security Boss Blames Russia's GRU for Years-Long Energy-Sector Hacks

Russia's Main Intelligence Directorate (GRU) is implicated in a years-long campaign targeting Western energy providers and their suppliers by exploiting vulnerabilities and misconfigurations in network edge devices like routers and VPN concentrators. Since 2021, the operation has evolved to prioritize "Living off the Land" techniques, using misconfigured devices and stolen user credentials to reduce detection risk. Attackers establish persistence via compromised EC2 instances and use packet capture or traffic analysis for credential-replay attacks, posing a high risk to Florida's significant cloud-hosted energy infrastructure.

Russian APT28 Runs Credential-Stealing Campaign Targeting Energy and Policy Organizations

Russian state-sponsored cyber threat actor APT28 (also known as BlueDelta), linked to the General Staff of the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation (GRU), has initiated a targeted credential-harvesting campaign against energy and nuclear research agencies, as well as policy think tanks. Observed in February and September 2025, the campaign utilizes phishing emails containing PDF lures related to geopolitical events to redirect victims to fake login pages mimicking Microsoft Outlook and Sophos VPN portals. To evade detection, the attackers leverage legitimate disposable infrastructure services like Webhook, ngrok, and InfinityFree to host these malicious pages.

Energy Sector - Recommendations

- Conduct an immediate audit of all network edge devices, remote access gateways, and VPN concentrators for proper configuration.
- Review authentication logs for signs of credential reuse between device management interfaces and online services.
- Enforce multi-factor authentication (MFA) for all remote access and cloud services to prevent successful credential replay.
- Deploy FIDO2/WebAuthn-compliant multi-factor authentication, which is resistant to the credential harvesting and replay attacks employed in these campaigns.

Financial Services Sector

North Korean Cybercrime Focuses on High-Value Financial Targets

North Korean state-sponsored threat groups are achieving record success in financially motivated operations, stealing at least \$2.02 billion in cryptocurrency so far this year. These groups are shifting strategy to target "bigger fish" for larger payouts, utilizing sophisticated money laundering mechanisms that break funds into small amounts across diverse avenues to avoid detection. Florida's growing fintech and technological sectors represent a high-value target for these operatives, who often fund state weapon and cyber programs through these illicit gains.

Financial Services Sector - Recommendations

- Implement network defenses specifically designed to block sophisticated phishing and social engineering targeting financial personnel.
- Segment internal networks heavily, isolating financial planning and cryptocurrency systems from standard enterprise infrastructure.

- Monitor third-party code dependencies and software supply chains rigorously for signs of compromise.

Food and Agriculture Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Government Services and Facilities Sector

Ransomware Attack Targets Major Federal Contractor Serving Critical Agencies

The TridentLocker ransomware group recently exfiltrated 3.4 GB of data from an isolated file transfer system belonging to Sedgwick Government Solutions. This subsidiary provides claims and risk management for critical agencies including CISA, DHS, and the Department of Labor, and serves municipal agencies in all 50 states. This incident creates significant supply chain risk for Florida entities that may rely on this contractor for essential services.

Cyberattack Forces British High School to Cancel Classes and Delay Reopening

Higham Lane School in the UK was forced to delay its term reopening after a cyberattack disabled all digital services, including telephones, emails, and student management systems. The school, enrolling about 1,500 students, implemented incident response protocols and notified authorities like the ICO. This follows a broader trend of systematic targeting of the education sector by ransomware groups.

Government Services and Facilities Sector - Recommendations

- Vet all third-party contractors who handle sensitive data to ensure they meet minimum security standards.
- Enforce multi-factor authentication on all vendor access points and file transfer services.
- Establish offline fallback procedures for safety-critical services like school emergency communications.

Healthcare and Public Health Sector

Owner of Lewiston Hospital Vastly Underestimated Scope of May Data Breach

Covenant Health revised the scope of a May 2025 data breach, confirming that 478,000 individuals were affected—nearly 50 times the initial estimate of 10,000. This highlights a critical lesson for Florida’s healthcare providers: initial breach assessments often require substantial revision following thorough forensic analysis. Separately, the pharmaceutical firm

Inotiv reported a ransomware attack exfiltrating 176 GB of data, impacting nearly 10,000 individuals.

Healthcare and Public Health Sector - Recommendations

- Ensure comprehensive forensic analysis is completed rapidly to determine the full scope of compromise immediately following an incident.
- Implement detailed network visibility tools to monitor system logs and confirm the extent of unauthorized exfiltration.
- Prioritize independent verification of data breach statistics before making public disclosures.

Information Technology Sector

Coordinated Chinese Hacking Groups Exploit Microsoft SharePoint Vulnerabilities (ToolShell Campaign)

Three distinct Chinese hacking organizations—Linen Typhoon, Violet Typhoon, and Storm-2603—contemporaneously exploited four vulnerabilities in on-premise Microsoft SharePoint beginning in July 2025. These flaws (CVE-2025-49704, 49706, 53770, and 53771) allowed attackers to bypass authentication and execute remote commands, granting access to confidential procurement data and legal filings. At least 400 governments and businesses globally were affected, including U.S. federal and state agencies.

Information Technology Sector - Recommendations

- Apply all available vendor patches immediately for SharePoint vulnerabilities and rotate all cryptographic material (MachineKey).
- Monitor remote employees for "impossible travel" indicators and anomalous behavior, treating suspicious RMM tool installation as a high-priority signal.
- Restrict unauthorized access to SharePoint servers and isolate them from core authentication services.

Nuclear Reactors, Materials, and Waste Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period, although the targeted credential-harvesting campaign by Russian state-sponsored cyber threat actor APT28 (also known as BlueDelta), included an R&D agency with remits in energy, nuclear science, and associated technology development.

Transportation Systems Sector

No sector-relevant incidents were identified during this two-week tracking period.

Water and Wastewater Systems Sector

Romanian National Water Agency Hit by BitLocker Ransomware Attack

Romania's national water management agency was hit by a ransomware attack on December 22, 2025, that locked staff out of 1,000 computer systems by leveraging the legitimate Windows tool BitLocker. This "living off the land binary" (LOLBin) technique helps attackers evade security controls by using existing system tools, e.g., `cmd.exe`, `powershell.exe`, and `certutil.exe`. While hydrotechnical operations like dams remained unaffected, the loss of email servers forced a transition to telephone and radio communications. This method is highly transferable to Florida's water sector due to the common use of standard enterprise Windows environments.

Water and Wastewater Systems Sector - Recommendations

- Implement strict control over administrative tools, restricting utilities like BitLocker to authorized and monitored administrators.
- Segment the network aggressively to maintain absolute separation between IT and OT infrastructure.
- Routinely exercise emergency communication protocols (telephone/radio) to ensure service continuity when digital systems fail.